

I love reading advice columns about money problems in relationships. According to some of these columnists, you should come to your first date equipped with your entire credit report, a breakdown of thirty-seven categories of your spending, plus a printout of your investment portfolio and your twenty-year goals.

Have these people ever actually been on a date?

Get real. Nobody talks about money that early on (which is fine). But so many of us don't know how to talk about money at *any* point in our relationship—much less when tempers flare.

The idea of sitting down proactively for a frank money discussion is so foreign to us that we simply ignore the (correct) advice to do so. Here's the most common sentiment: "Uh, okay, so I'm supposed to have these painful conversations about money—a topic I'm not even confident about—that I know will make us uncomfortable and probably cause a huge fight. Eh . . . I'll just ignore this and deal with it later."

Just like flossing, it's easier to ignore it until you end up with a real problem. I get it! By the way, I'm guilty of this too. When I was dating my now-wife, I had already heard all the advice to discuss your finances with your partner. Guess what: I ignored it! I didn't talk about money until she eventually brought it up first.

There is a better way. You can be honest and realistic with money conversations, but the most important thing is starting with your Rich Life—not judgment. It's magical when you realize you're rowing in the same direction: You can dream bigger, begin to live your Rich Life faster, and have more fun doing it together.

Now I absolutely love talking about money and relationships. When I get the chance to speak to a couple about their money psychology, I can see their entire relationship trajectory change in a single conversation. Money usually has such a negative power in relationships, but with a few small changes, it can be incredibly constructive and connective. You don't have to agree on everything, but the simple process of carving out time to talk about money proactively—*before* there's a crisis—sets a powerfully positive precedent.